

Lowdown
on
SPORTS



By Charles Johnson

MAJOR league club owners aren't as hesitant as they once were in gambling with minor leaguers as field managers.

Not too long ago every time a change was made some old timer who had been around a long time would get priority.

The result was that no matter how often some of them had been fired for one reason or another they'd always pop up with a fairly good job in some spot later on.

Gene Mauch is one of several men who have proved their ability in the minors to get a chance. His elevation to the Philadelphia post was a surprise only because it came with the 1960 season only one day old.

Bill Rigney of San Francisco, Joe Gordon with Cleveland, Bob Elliott with Kansas City, Danny Murtough with Pittsburgh and Walter Alston of Los Angeles are recent graduates of the minors.

Mauch won his chance after only two full years of bossing the Minneapolis team although he had had one fling earlier as a player pilot.

He was snubbed by Boston last year when Bill Jurgens was given the nod over him even though almost every one in the system thought highly of him.

There are many more managers in the smaller leagues who have earned a break, but they can't get it. Most notable example is Ben Ogerahy of Louisville. He has proved he has the qualifications, but he's always passed by when an opening develops.

Most managers play the game the same way. Some are bolder than others. Some are conservative.

They must have two other qualifications. The most important is handling men to keep harmony and a good team spirit. The other is sound direction of a pitching staff. Not too many have this knack and it proven their undoing in short order.

Look at the number of men who have held different managerial posts over the years.

Charley Dressen has had plenty of jobs. He was rescued from a Los Angeles coaching role during the winter to take over at Milwaukee.

Charley Grimm has been fired and re-hired about as often as any one that ever was in fast company.

Fred Hutchinson, now with Cincinnati, moves in and out of the American and National leagues quite regularly. Fired from one assignment, he returns to the minors and then bounces back again.

Jimmy Dykes has moved around pretty often, too. He was a Pittsburgh coach when Detroit picked him off in mid-season of 1959.

They advance players as soon as they cut the mustard in the lower loops. Why shouldn't managers get the same break?

Baseball an Asset

CRITICS to the contrary, a professional baseball team is worth a lot to any community as an entertainment feature.

The fact that public support has fallen off some in the minor leagues in recent years doesn't mean interest in the sport is on the wane.

Baseball's only trouble today is that it has so much competition from other sources. Let's list a few. They would include boating, fishing, golf, tennis, adult attention to Little League competition, suburban living and daylight saving.

The trouble is that those who direct the national pastime on an organized basis haven't kept up with competition from these new avenues. They have done very little to make their game so attractive that their normal following doesn't leave them.

More and more families are doing things as groups when seeking recreation. If baseball had an attractive price for ma, pa and the kids they might find their way into the park often.

More stress on free admittances for boys and girls as done in the old knothole days would increase enthusiasm and interest.

Too many large cities take professional baseball for granted.

It isn't a civic duty to support any sport, but there are certain occasions when every one should rally around for group participation such as on opening days and attractive series.